

bian update arrived, with the much anticipated Nokia N8 handset. However, after the excitement had settled down, people realised that Symbian3 still has a long way to go before it can truly square up to the likes of the iOS and the Android.

Windows Phone 7: This is Microsoft's desperate attempt to grab a solid chunk of the smartphone market. The previous gen Windows Mobile 6.5 is dated, and truly been replaced by the Blackberry OS. Windows Phone 7 does come with a completely new interface, and incorporates the best of both worlds with business applications and entertainment features. Inexplicably, the "copy-paste" feature is missing and will arrive with the first software update.

The Others: Apart from the biggies, we had a lot of other operating systems who came, saw, and didn't conquer as well as they had planned, and still stuck around to grab a share of the pie. Samsung's bada OS, for one, was loaded on the truly amazing Wave. Nokia's Maemo bid faltered quite quickly, with the N900 not capturing the imagination of the buyer. Because of the lack of good apps? Partly the reason, we believe. HP is all set to pump in a new lease of life into the Palm stable, with rapid development of the WebOS.

The rise of apps

It is true that a good smartphone is almost a replacement for the PC, as far as accessing email, IM and documents is concerned. However, the rise of the app ecosystem has also helped widen the appeal of a genre of phones which were considered 'complicated' and 'serious' till now.

The apps span across every imaginable genre- office suites, productivity enhancing apps, entertainment, mobile versions of popular PC software, games etc. There are apps which can make far-fetched noises. Basically, there is an app for every task imaginable, and then some!

The rise of the App stores can be attributed to Apple, for not only popularising the concept, but also working quickly on enhancing the number and variety of apps available. The App Store now has 3,00,000 apps, and counting.



For those on the move

Some are paid, some are free. An important thing to note is that Apple is now looking to offer the iPhone/iPod Touch as a portable gaming console.

However, Google is loading the Android Market very quickly, and has crossed a million apps. Incidentally, a lot of the apps that cost money to download from the Apple App Store are free on the Android Market. Undoubtedly, Apple App Store and the Android Market are two of the largest reservoirs of applications out there.

Blackberry, Nokia and the others tried with their own app stores. But none have come even remotely close to the leaders. Nokia upgraded the Ovi Store to add more apps and gear it up for the Symbian3 launch. Research in Motion has been often criticized for lacking the drive to make the Blackberry App World better, quickly.

Heights of popularity

The best example of how smartphone apps are now the next big thing is Angry Birds. This is one game which saw 1 million downloads on the day of launch on the Android platform. By December last year, the game had been downloaded 50 million times from the Apple App Store. And yes, Angry Birds has arrived on the Playstation platform, and will very soon be on the PC as well.

This just goes on to show how solid the app ecosystem has become.



What to expect in 2011?

- With the growing popularity of the tablet devices, expect a lot of action from the Android corner. More apps will be optimised for the multiple screen sizes- phones and tablets. With more tablets on the way, app developers will be working overtime to ensure that their apps are rendered perfectly on the huge variety of

screen sizes and resolutions. Google plans to make the Android Market available on the web as well, in the coming months. And yes, Gingerbread (Android 3.0) is coming as well.

- Apple can't be expected to stay silent and there will be the inevitable iPhone 5 launch and probably an update to the iOS4.
- Blackberry will want to spread the OS6 goodness to its previous generation phones as well, along with the new launches.
- We're truly surprised that Microsoft is betting big on the tablet market with Windows 7, and not Windows Phone 7. Since Windows Phone 7 is ready for the smartphone, it will be easier to port it to the slightly larger tablet as well. Maybe Microsoft will wake up and smell the coffee.
- Speaking of WP7, the developments with regards to its app store will be watched closely. Since this is Microsoft's big smartphone bet, the app ecosystem needs to be in perfect order.
- Nokia will need to take an executive decision- stick with Symbian 3 or switch completely to Meego. "With big-wigs in the business, their muscle power and an already existing base of consumers, services and networks a single OS or platforms is difficult to foresee but yes in the quest to be the best, the offerings are just going to be better and better by each of them. The more successful ones would be the ones who would play the convergence game. Google Android for instance is on the mobile, tablets, televisions, cars and expected to be in many more consumer electronic products.

-Naoman Kazi, Business Lead, Hungama Digital Media Entertainment Ltd.

However, apps will continue to rule. With over 500 million phones expected to be sold in 2011, expect a lot of apps to be downloaded. And by lot, we mean lots of millions! With people being more open to pay for apps now, app developers will have a gala time. All they need to do is make a worthwhile app, price it right on the best suitable platform, and they are all set. ■